

What Is This Room For?

One room. Twenty minutes. Three things to do about it.

ONE ROOM. NOT THE HOUSE.

Do this for a single room, finish it, and stop. You can run it again next week for the next one — but a house-wide audit in one sitting is how this ends up half-done in a notebook you never open again.

1 Pick the room

1 minute

Not the worst one. **The one you're in most.** Effort spent on a room you use daily pays back daily; the spare room can wait another year, as it has been doing.

2 What's its job?

3 minutes

Pick **one**. Rooms can do two things, but only one of them wins when they disagree — and deciding which now is the entire point of this exercise.

- ☐ **Sleeping**
And nothing else. Everything else in here is a guest.
- ☐ **Cooking and eating**
- ☐ **Sitting with other people**
Talking, eating, watching something together.
- ☐ **Sitting on your own**
Reading, watching, recovering.
- ☐ **Working or studying**
- ☐ **Getting in and out**
Keys, shoes, coat, mail, bag.
- ☐ **Storing things**
A real answer. A room that's honestly storage beats one pretending to be a study.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

"*This room is for ____.*" Most people have never once said what a room in their home is for, which is exactly why it drifted into being for everything.

3

What's fighting it?

10 minutes

Tick what's true **in this room**. These six cover almost everything — they're the failure modes, not a list of chores.

- ☐ **Something in here has no home.**
It gets moved, never put away, because there's nowhere to put it away to. Usually it's most of the clutter.
- ☐ **Furniture is doing a job it wasn't meant for.**
The coffee table is storage. The dining table is a desk. The chair is a laundry pile.
- ☐ **You clear it before you can use it.**
If starting the room's actual job needs a tidy-up first, the room isn't doing its job.
- ☐ **There's a pile nobody owns.**
It's been there weeks. Nobody put it there and nobody will move it.
- ☐ **One light, in the ceiling.**
The cheapest thing on this list to fix and the one that changes the room most.
- ☐ **The room has two jobs and they're losing to each other.**
Work and rest in the same space is the common one. Neither happens properly.

4

Three things, with a date

5 minutes

Not everything you ticked. **Three.** A list of three with dates gets done; a list of nine is a mood.

WHAT I'M GOING TO DO

DONE BY

WHO'S CHECKING

THE THIRD COLUMN ISN'T DECORATION

Name a real person and tell them. Ask them to check whether you *started* on time, not just whether you finished — starting is the part that goes wrong. A date nobody else knows about is a wish.